A POLL OUTSOURCED

The poll campaign for all three parties—BJP, Congress and AAP—is led by leaders who don't reside in Gujarat, at least not now



NARENDRA MODI
The prime minister is the face of the BJP not just in his home state but across India. He is micro-managing the polls, with all teams reporting to him, though chief minister Bhupendrabhai Patel continues to be the CM face



ARVIND KEJRIWAL
With no prominent state-level leader, the Delhi CM is the face of AAP, supported by his deputy in Delhi, Manish Sisodia. The AAP slogan in Gujarat is '*Ek moko Kejriwal ne* (Give one opportunity to Kejriwal)'



ASHOK GEHLOT
The Rajasthan CM was credited for the superlative performance by the Congress in 2017. He is the poll observer again this time. But unlike Modi and Kejriwal, he is not the face of the campaign, leaving room for the Gandhi family and local leaders

KEY PLAYERS



BHUPENDRABHAI PATEL, 60 (BJP): Incumbent CM is likely to get a second term if the party wins. A Patidar, he is the energetic, urban face of Ahmedabad. Has worked closely with the PMO since he took over in late 2021



C.R. PATIL, 67 (BJP): The state president is also a Lok Sabha MP and a south Gujarat strongman. Will make a strong claim for the CM's post if the party wins more than 125 seats



ISUDAN GADHVI, 40 (AAP): The party's national joint general secretary is a former TV anchor. Known for his oratory, he is projected as a young son-of-the-soil leader

urban areas will help them indirectly.

With an eye on the middle- and lower middle-class votes, AAP has set the agenda with its trademark promises of free power, education and health. The electricity bill waiver of up to 300 units per household has already got Gujaratis talking. Recruitment for vacant government posts and unemployment benefits are other issues that have got traction. Speaking in Rajkot in August, Kejriwal explained how an AAP government would recruit for one million state jobs: "Talati exams will be held in February 2023, results in April and postings the same month. TET exams for teachers in May, results in July and postings in August. PSI and ASI exams in November and so on." While doing so, the AAP convenor also attacked the BJP state government on the issue of paper leaks, which has delayed government recruitment processes many times in recent years.

Kejriwal is even trying to win brownie points out of the announcements made by other parties. On October 19, when Modi inspected a model classroom and announced a Rs 4,260-crore project—Mission Schools of Excellence—to create smart public school classrooms in the state, the Delhi CM immediately commented that making education in government schools part of the mainstream political discourse was his biggest achievement. He has also missed no opportunity to assert his Hindu identity, even going to the extent of saying he has a natural right to invoke Lord Krishna's name as he was born on Krishna Janmashtami. In fact, his latest was an appeal to the Centre to include photos of Hindu deities Lakshmi and Ganesh on currency notes to bring prosperity to India.

AAP's promises don't end with education and healthcare. From hiking salaries/ allowances of police personnel, state government employees, anganwadi workers and *talati*s to paying for the pilgrimage trips of senior citizens to introducing tax amnesty for traders, Kejriwal has something for every social segment. "AAP has got everyone's attention. One can see why Modi and Shah are spending significant time in Gujarat...it shows their nervousness. I do sense a dissatisfaction among the middle class, but how it is channelised remains to be seen," says sociologist and political analyst Ghanshyam Shah, conceding that the battle is difficult to predict at the moment.

What goes against AAP is its weak organisational structure. The party



SECOND STRIKE? Gujarat poll observer Ashok Gehlot with Congress workers

NANDAN DAVE